South Island Road Trip: Christchurch to Queenstown

Self-drive itinerary for two adults, Saturday 6 to Sunday 14 March 2027 (8 nights). Prepared 9 November 2026. Only the flights are booked; nothing in this plan has been booked yet.

Overview

Item	Detail
Dates	Land Christchurch Airport (CHC) Sat 6 Mar 2027 at 14:30. Fly out of Queenstown Airport (ZQN) Sun 14 Mar 2027 at 11:00. 8 nights.
Route	Christchurch, Arthur's Pass, Hokitika, Franz Josef and Fox Glaciers (2 nights), Haast Pass, Wānaka, Lindis Pass, Aoraki/Mount Cook, Lake Tekapo, Waitaki lakes, Oamaru, Dunedin and Otago Peninsula, Central Otago, Queenstown. One-way, about 2,000 km, with no road driven twice except short spurs.
Trip focus	Mountains and lookouts, lakes, glaciers and wildlife (kea, kiwi, little blue penguins, yellow-eyed penguins, royal albatross, fur seals). Early starts and full days.
Home bases	Christchurch Airport (1), Franz Josef (2), Wānaka (1), Lake Tekapo (1), Oamaru (1), Dunedin (1), Queenstown (1). Accor (ALL) on 3 nights: Christchurch, Tekapo and Queenstown. The other towns have no Accor hotel.
Driver	One driver, full Australian licence in English (valid in New Zealand for up to 12 months from arrival; carry it at all times).
Hard rules applied	At most 500 km a day (the longest day is about 440 km). No driving after dark: every day's last drive ends at least 1.5 hours before sunset, and no drive starts before sunrise. No boats or ferries of any kind. No beaches. No walk longer than about 1.5 hours return. No sightseeing on 14 March.

The plan at a glance. Day 1 Christchurch kiwi; Day 2 Arthur's Pass and Hokitika Gorge to Franz Josef; Day 3 Lake Matheson, glacier helicopter flight with snow landing, glacier valley walk and kiwi centre; Day 4 Haast Pass waterfalls and Blue Pools to Wānaka; Day 5 Lindis Pass, Aoraki/Mount Cook walks and Tasman Glacier, then Lake Tekapo; Day 6 Mount John lookout, Mackenzie and Waitaki lakes, Oamaru blue penguins; Day 7 Katiki Point seals, royal albatross and yellow-eyed penguins on the Otago Peninsula; Day 8 Central Otago, Kawarau Gorge, Arrowtown, Glenorchy road and Skyline Queenstown; Day 9 return the car and fly.

Assumptions for questions you did not answer

- **Food:** no dietary restrictions. Meals are suggested but not booked.
- **Activity budget:** you set NZ$300 a night for rooms but no activity budget. The two scenic flights are the only expensive items, so they are marked optional with price ranges. The plan works without them.
- **Entry:** you are Australian citizens, who need no visa or NZeTA. If either of you holds another passport, check NZeTA and visa rules now.
- **Car:** not booked yet. I assume a standard automatic car or small SUV with unlimited kilometres, collected at Christchurch Airport and returned at Queenstown Airport (one-way). Everything in the plan is on sealed roads except one optional gravel spur (Clay Cliffs, Day 6).
- **"No beaches":** I read this as never walking onto a beach. Two short coastal stops (Knights Point, Day 4; Katiki Point, Day 7) are cliff-top lookouts above the sea with no sand. Skip them if you would rather avoid the coast entirely.
- **"Never after dark":** I read this as no driving between sunset and sunrise. Evening activities on Day 5 (optional), Day 6 and Day 8 are reached on foot from the hotel.

Sunrise and sunset (NZ daylight time, UTC+13, in force until 4 April 2027)

Place	Date	Sunrise	Sunset
Christchurch	Sat 6 Mar	07:14	20:08
Franz Josef	Sun 7 to Tue 9 Mar	07:25 to 07:27	20:16 to 20:12
Wānaka	Tue 9 / Wed 10 Mar	07:31 / 07:32	20:17 / 20:15
Lake Tekapo	Wed 10 / Thu 11 Mar	07:27 / 07:28	20:10 / 20:08

Place	Date	Sunrise	Sunset
Oamaru / Dunedin	Thu 11 / Fri 12 Mar	07:26 / 07:28	20:06 / 20:07
Queenstown	Sat 13 / Sun 14 Mar	07:38 / 07:39	20:12 / 20:10

Calculated with the standard NOAA sunrise/sunset formula for each town; expect up to a few minutes of difference from published tables. Mountains block the sun earlier in deep valleys (Franz Josef, Mount Cook), so it gets dim before sunset there.

Daily driving and daylight check

Day	Route	Approx. km	Time at wheel	Last drive ends	Sunset	Status
1 Sat 6	CHC Airport, Willowbank, hotel	25	0:30	~17:45	20:08	OK
2 Sun 7	Christchurch to Franz Josef via Arthur's Pass and Hokitika Gorge	~440	~6:00	~18:00	20:16	OK, longest day
3 Mon 8	Franz Josef, Lake Matheson, return	~75	~1:15	~14:45	20:14	OK
4 Tue 9	Franz Josef to Wānaka via Haast Pass	~290	~4:00	~18:20	20:17	OK
5 Wed 10	Wānaka to Mount Cook to Lake Tekapo	~340	~4:30	~17:45	20:10	OK
6 Thu 11	Tekapo to Oamaru via Waitaki lakes	~250	~3:30	~16:15	20:06	OK
7 Fri 12	Oamaru to Dunedin and Otago Peninsula	~200	~3:00	~18:25	20:07	OK
8 Sat 13	Dunedin to Queenstown via Central Otago and Glenorchy road	~395	~5:15	~17:30	20:12	OK
9 Sun 14	Hotel to Queenstown Airport	~10	0:20	~08:30	(sunrise 07:39)	OK

Distances and times are estimates from standard route distances and include short detours. They do not include stops; the day plans below do. Total about 2,000 km. Days 2 and 8 are long for one driver: stop every 1.5 to 2 hours and use the drop-first items listed for each day if you are tired.

Day by day

Day 1, Saturday 6 March: Arrive Christchurch, first kiwi

Afternoon

- **14:30** Land at Christchurch Airport. Allow about an hour for passport control and biosecurity. Declare all food, and make sure walking shoes are clean of soil (fines apply).
- **~15:45** Collect the one-way rental car at the airport. Before leaving: check the spare tyre and fuel type, and that only the one driver is named. Note the car's fuel-tank size so you can plan refills.
- **16:00 to 17:00 Willowbank Wildlife Reserve**, 60 Hussey Road, Harewood (about 10 minutes from the airport). The nocturnal kiwi house claims guaranteed kiwi viewing, and there are other native birds. Sources give closing as 16:30 or 17:00, so check willowbank.co.nz. If the arrival runs late, skip it: you will also see kiwi at Franz Josef on Day 3. (I left out the International Antarctic Centre. It closes at 16:30 and needs about 3 hours.)
- **17:15** Supermarket run (water, snacks, breakfast items for early starts) at any large supermarket near the airport, then fill the fuel tank.

Evening

- Check in at **Novotel Christchurch Airport** (Accor), 30 Durey Road, at the airport. Park the car for the night. Dinner at the hotel restaurant or the airport. Early night.

Prep tonight

- Download offline Google Maps for Canterbury, the West Coast and Otago. Phone coverage is patchy on Arthur's Pass and absent on most of the Haast Pass.
- Check NZTA Journey Planner (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) for SH73 (Arthur's Pass) and SH6. Check the MetService forecast for Franz Josef for Day 3, and reconfirm the helicopter booking time.
- Alarm 06:15. Pack a day bag: rain jacket, warm layer, sunscreen, insect repellent (West Coast sandflies), water.

Day 2, Sunday 7 March: Arthur's Pass and Hokitika Gorge to Franz Josef (~440 km)

Morning

- **Wake 06:15. Depart 07:15** (sunrise 07:14) west on SH73 through Sheffield, where the Sheffield Pie Shop makes an optional pie stop (check opening hours).
- **08:30 to 09:15 Kura Tāwhiti / Castle Hill** (~95 km, 1 h 15 min): limestone boulders on an easy 30 to 45 minute walk. Optional 5 to 10 minute roadside stop at Lake Pearson on the way on.
- **10:00 to 11:10 Arthur's Pass village** (~50 km). **Devils Punchbowl Falls walk**: 2 km, about 1 hour return, steep with 400+ steps, signposted at the north end of the village. There is an unbridged crossing at Wardens Creek, so skip the walk after heavy rain. Look for **kea** (alpine parrots) around the village. Do not feed them, and keep the car's rubber seals and wipers in view.
- **11:25 to 11:40 Otira Viaduct Lookout**: viaduct and mountain views, with kea often here too.

Afternoon

- **~12:55 Hokitika** (~90 km). Lunch and **fuel**. Skip the beach and driftwood sign.
- **14:15 to 15:30 Hokitika Gorge** (33 km inland, about 35 min each way): turquoise river, a swing bridge and lookouts on a 45 minute to 1.5 hour loop. **Cut-off:** if you are not leaving Hokitika by 14:00, skip the gorge and drive straight south. Without it you reach Franz Josef about 1.5 hours earlier.
- **~16:05** Back on SH6 heading south via Ross, Harihari and Whataroa (~135 km, about 1 h 50 min). The road has many one-lane bridges: the give-way sign tells you who yields.

Evening

- **~18:00** Arrive Franz Josef (sunset 20:16) and check in for 2 nights (see Accommodation). Dinner in the village, for example Snakebite Brewery or Alice May on the main road.

Prep tonight

- Check the helicopter operator's weather message for tomorrow; operators decide on the morning. Fuel up in Franz Josef if below half. Alarm 06:30.

Day 3, Monday 8 March: Glacier day, Franz Josef and Fox (~75 km)

Morning

- **Depart 07:30** (sunrise 07:26) for **Lake Matheson / Te Ara Kairaumati**, Cook Flat Road, 6 km west of Fox Glacier township (30 km, 30 min). The mirror reflections of Aoraki/Mount Cook and Mt Tasman are best early on a calm morning. Easy 1 to 1.5 hour loop to the Jetty and View of Views; there is a café at the car park.
- **~09:20** Drive back to Franz Josef.
- **~10:30 Helicopter scenic flight with a snow landing (optional, recommended).** 20 to 40 minutes over Franz Josef and/or Fox Glacier with a few minutes standing on the snow at the top. Operators are on the Franz Josef main road, for example The Helicopter Line or Fox & Franz Josef Heliservices. Typically about NZ$300 to NZ$600 per person depending on length; check current prices. It is a helicopter, not a boat, but tell the pilot if motion sickness is a worry. **Weather backup:** if it is cancelled, ask to rebook for 15:00 today or 08:00 tomorrow (Day 4 still works with a 09:00 departure). If it cannot fly at all, book the Mount Cook ski-plane landing on Day 5 instead.
- I left out the glacier heli-hike: it involves 2 to 3 hours walking on ice, which is over your walking limit.

Afternoon

- **12:00** Lunch in Franz Josef village.
- **13:00 to 14:30 Franz Josef Glacier / Kā Roimata o Hine Hukatere Walk** (car park 5 km south of the village, Glacier Access Road): an easy walk up the river valley to a viewpoint of the glacier, about 1 to 1.5 hours return. Add the 20 minute **Sentinel Rock** walk from the same car park for a higher view. Check track status at the Westland Tai Poutini National Park visitor centre first: tracks close after rock falls or floods.
- **15:00 to 16:30 West Coast Wildlife Centre**, corner of Cron and Cowan Streets, Franz Josef (open about 08:30 to 18:00). See rowi and Haast tokoeka, two of the rarest kiwi. The optional 40 minute Backstage Pass tour must be booked; a recent review says there may be no eggs being incubated.
- **If it is a clear day and you still have energy:** the Fox Glacier South Side Walk (first glacier viewpoint about 40 min each way, so about 1.5 hours return) is an alternative to the valley walk. The old Fox Glacier valley road is closed indefinitely.

Evening

- Optional soak at the Glacier Hot Pools in the village. Dinner in the village.

Prep tonight

- **Fill the tank in Franz Josef.** The next fuel is Fox (25 km), then Haast (~120 km). Between Haast and Wānaka (~145 km) there may be only a small, sometimes unattended pump at Makarora.
- Check NZTA for **SH6 Haast Pass**. It closes for slips and floods, and there is no short detour. Alarm 06:45.

Day 4, Tuesday 9 March: Haast Pass waterfalls and Blue Pools to Wānaka (~290 km)

Morning

- **Depart 07:30** (sunrise 07:27). If the helicopter was moved to 08:00, depart about 09:00 instead and drop Roaring Billy Falls.
- **~09:15 Knights Point Lookout**: a cliff-top roadside viewpoint over the Tasman Sea, about 5 minutes. Fur seals are sometimes on the rocks below. It is not a beach; skip it if you prefer.
- **~09:45 Haast: fuel** and toilets.
- **10:15 to 10:45 Roaring Billy Falls**: 25 minute return forest walk.
- **11:05 Thunder Creek Falls** (10 min return) and **11:25 Fantail Falls** (5 min), both signposted on SH6. Then a stop at the **Haast Pass / Tioripatea** summit lookout.
- **12:00 to 13:05 Blue Pools Track**, near Makarora: 3 km, about 1 hour return, with swing bridges over glacier-blue pools. The track reopened in May 2025 after bridge repairs.

Afternoon

- **13:20** Lunch at Makarora (café hours vary; carry snacks).
- **14:15 to 15:30 Lake lookouts**: roadside stops along Lake Wānaka, **The Neck** (the strip of land between Lake Hāwea and Lake Wānaka) and the Lake Hāwea lookout.
- **~15:45** Arrive Wānaka and check in.
- **16:45 to 18:15 Mount Iron Track** (car park on SH84, 2 km from town): a 1 to 1.5 hour loop with a 240 m climb and a 360-degree view of Lake Wānaka and the mountains. This is the short-walk alternative to Roys Peak, which takes 5 to 6 hours.

Evening

- **18:30 That Wānaka Tree**, a willow growing in the lake by the lakefront path, a few minutes on foot from town. Dinner on Ardmore Street, for example Big Fig or Kai Whakapai.

Prep tonight

- **Fill the tank in Wānaka**, or plan to fill in Twizel tomorrow. Do not rely on fuel at Mount Cook Village.
- If the Franz Josef flight did not happen, book the Mount Cook ski-plane flight for about 14:00 tomorrow. Alarm 06:45.

Day 5, Wednesday 10 March: Lindis Pass, Aoraki/Mount Cook and Lake Tekapo (~340 km)

Morning

- **Depart 07:35** (sunrise 07:32) on SH6 and SH8 via Tarras.
- **~08:40 Lindis Pass** summit lookout: tussock high country, 10 minutes.
- **~09:40 Twizel:** coffee and **fuel**.
- **~10:30 Lake Pukaki and Peter's Lookout** on SH80, the classic view of turquoise Lake Pukaki with Aoraki/Mount Cook behind.
- **~11:15** Arrive Aoraki/Mount Cook Village (55 km up SH80). Optional quick stop at the DOC Visitor Centre for track conditions.
- **11:30 to 12:40 Kea Point Track** from White Horse Hill car park: about 1 hour return. It ends at a lookout over the Mueller Glacier moraine lake, Mt Sefton's hanging glaciers and Aoraki. (The full Hooker Valley Track takes about 3 hours return, too long for your limit.)

Afternoon

- **12:45** Lunch at the Old Mountaineers' Café in the village.
- **~14:00 Option A, ski-plane flight with a glacier landing (optional, or the backup if Franz Josef did not fly).** Mt Cook Ski Planes & Helicopters flies from Mount Cook Airport, just south of the village, and is the operator licensed to land on the Tasman Glacier. Flights are about 25 to 55 minutes, with about 10 minutes on the snow on landing flights. Published prices run roughly NZ$480 to NZ$700+ per person; check current prices. **Option B (no flight):** walk the first part of the Hooker Valley Track to the first swing bridge and back, about 1 hour.
- **15:15 to 16:00 Tasman Glacier View Track**, at the end of Tasman Valley Road (8 km): about 30 to 40 minutes return, steep steps, with a view of the Tasman Glacier terminal lake and its icebergs. The glacier boat trip on that lake is excluded (no boats).
- **16:15** Depart for Lake Tekapo (about 113 km, 1 h 30 min), with a stop at the Lake Pukaki lookout and visitor centre on SH8 if you did not stop this morning.
- **~17:45** Arrive Lake Tekapo and check in.

Evening

- **~19:30 Church of the Good Shepherd**, Pioneer Drive, at sunset (20:10). **Walk** the lakefront path from your hotel (about 15 to 20 minutes) so you are not driving after sunset. The Mackenzie Basin is an International Dark Sky Reserve.
- **Optional stargazing:** Dark Sky Project tours leave from their base in Tekapo village by tour bus, so you do not drive. In March they start late (about 21:30 or later) and run about 2 hours. Book ahead and check the cloud forecast. Dinner beforehand, for example Kohan Japanese on SH8.

Prep tonight

- Mount John summit road opens at 09:00 (about $8 per car at the gate, cash or EFTPOS). No early alarm unless you want sunrise at the church (07:28).

Day 6, Thursday 11 March: Mount John, Mackenzie and Waitaki lakes to Oamaru penguins (~250 km)

Morning

- **Optional 07:15** Walk to the Church of the Good Shepherd for sunrise (07:28).
- **09:00 to 10:15 Mount John summit** (Takapō): drive to the summit when the gate opens. There are 360-degree views of Lake Tekapo, Lake Alexandrina and the Southern Alps, and breakfast at the Astro Café (about 09:00 to 15:00; the road closes in bad weather).
- **10:30** Depart south on SH8 to Twizel (57 km). Optional 15 minute stop at the **High Country Salmon** farm shop on the canal just north of Twizel.
- **~12:15 Omarama:** lunch and fuel.

Afternoon

- **12:45 to 13:30 Omarama Clay Cliffs (optional):** eroded pinnacles reached by a gravel road on private land, with a small honesty-box fee. **Check your rental agreement first**, because some exclude gravel roads. Otherwise skip it.
- **13:45 to 15:00 Waitaki lakes** on SH83: the Lake Benmore dam lookout near Otematata, then Lake Aviemore and Lake Waitaki along the road, with lakeside stops as you like.
- **~15:15 Elephant Rocks** near Duntroon: limestone formations in a paddock, 20 minutes.
- **~16:15** Arrive Oamaru. Check in at accommodation **within walking distance of the penguin colony** (Waterfront Road), so you can walk there and back tonight.
- **16:45 to 18:00** Victorian Precinct (Harbour and Tyne Streets) and Steampunk HQ (check closing time) on foot.

Evening

- **18:15** Early dinner in town.
- **~20:00 Oamaru Blue Penguin Colony evening viewing**, 2 Waterfront Road. **Walk, do not drive.** Little blue penguins come ashore around and after dusk (sunset 20:06). Seating opens before dusk; book the exact session time on penguins.co.nz. A Premium (closer) seat costs more. Sightings are likely but not guaranteed, and there is no photography. Walk back by about 21:30 to 22:00.

Prep tonight

- Confirm the albatross and OPERA tour times for tomorrow. Alarm 07:15.

Day 7, Friday 12 March: Katiki Point, Dunedin and Otago Peninsula wildlife (~200 km)

Morning

- **Depart 08:30** south on SH1.
- **09:15 to 10:00 Katiki Point Lighthouse** (Moeraki, signposted off SH1, last few km on a narrow road): a short cliff-top path to a lookout above fur seals, with yellow-eyed penguins sometimes visible. Stay behind the fences and at least 20 m from wildlife. This plan skips the nearby Moeraki Boulders because they are on a beach.
- **~11:15** Arrive Dunedin (75 km). **Signal Hill Lookout**: city, harbour and peninsula views, 20 minutes.
- **12:15** Lunch in the city centre, for example Vogel St Kitchen.

Afternoon

- **13:00** Drive onto the Otago Peninsula via **Highcliff Road** (narrow and winding, with lookouts over the harbour and ocean), then down to the harbour road.
- **14:00 to 15:30 Royal Albatross Centre**, 1259 Harington Point Road, Taiaroa Head. The **Unique Taiaroa tour** (1.5 hours, about NZ$82 per person) includes viewing nesting northern royal albatross from a glassed observatory, plus Fort Taiaroa. Windy afternoons are best for albatross in flight. Do not choose the "Double Albatross" or "Triple Crown" combos: both include a boat cruise.

- **16:00 to 17:30 The OPERA** (Otago Peninsula Eco Restoration Alliance, formerly Penguin Place), Harington Point Road, 5 minutes from the albatross centre. This is a land-based guided tour of about 90 minutes: briefing, a penguin hospital visit when birds are in care, and covered hides and trenches to see **yellow-eyed penguins** (hoiho), about NZ$68 per person. **Book the latest afternoon slot that finishes by 18:00.** Do not book the 19:30 twilight tour, which would mean driving back after dark.
- **17:40** Drive back to Dunedin along Portobello Road (about 45 minutes), arriving about 18:25. Sunset is 20:07.

Evening

- Check in at your Dunedin hotel. Dinner in the Octagon / George Street area on foot.

Prep tonight

- **Fill the tank** tonight or on the way out. It is a long day tomorrow, so alarm 06:30.

Day 8, Saturday 13 March: Central Otago, Kawarau Gorge, Glenorchy road and Queenstown (~395 km)

Morning

- **Depart 07:35** (sunrise 07:30). Take SH1 to Milton, then SH8 via Lawrence, Roxburgh and Alexandra.
- **~09:45 Roxburgh / Alexandra:** coffee break, and fruit stalls in season.
- **~10:30 Clyde and Lake Dunstan** lookouts, then **Cromwell Heritage Precinct** beside the lake (30 minutes).
- **~11:45 Kawarau Gorge:** the Roaring Meg lookout, then the **Kawarau Gorge Suspension Bridge** (12:05 to 12:35), where you can watch the original commercial bungy from the viewing decks.
- **~12:50 Arrowtown:** lunch, and the 20 minute Arrowtown Chinese Settlement walk.

Afternoon

- **14:00** Drive the **Glenorchy Road** along Lake Wakatipu (46 km from Queenstown, about 45 minutes), stopping at the **Bennetts Bluff** lookout.
- **~15:20 Glenorchy:** the Glenorchy Lagoon walkway (boardwalks, 30 to 60 minutes) and the lakefront wharf shed, with mountain views up the Dart and Rees valleys.
- **16:20** Drive back to Queenstown (about 50 minutes). **Fill the tank to full** for the rental return, at Frankton or in town. Check in by about 17:30 and park the car for the night.
- **Drop first if tired:** skip Glenorchy. That saves about 92 km and 2 hours, and puts you in Queenstown at about 14:30.

Evening

- **18:15 to 20:30 Skyline Queenstown gondola**, Brecon Street, about 10 minutes **on foot** from the Novotel. The Bob's Peak lookout over Lake Wakatipu and The Remarkables is best at sunset (20:12). Dinner at Stratosfare at the top or back in town, for example Fergburger, 42 Shotover Street. The Kiwi Birdlife Park at the gondola base is a rainy-day alternative.

Prep tonight

- Pack, check in online for the 11:00 flight, and photograph the car's fuel gauge and odometer. Confirm the return location and opening time at Queenstown Airport.

Day 9, Sunday 14 March: Return the car and fly (no sightseeing)

- **07:00** Breakfast. **08:00** Leave the hotel (sunrise 07:39). Queenstown Airport is about 8 km away (15 to 20 minutes). Top up fuel in Frankton if it is not already full.
- **~08:30** Return the car at the Queenstown Airport rental return area and walk to the terminal.
- **~09:00** Check in and bag drop for the 11:00 flight. If it is an international flight, counters usually close 60 minutes before departure; check with your airline.

Accommodation (none booked yet)

Each pick is a room with two beds (twin, or two queen or double beds). Target is NZ$300 or less per night. Accor properties come first wherever a town has one. Prices are not quoted because March rates change daily. Book flexible, free-cancellation rates now and check the room type says two beds.

Night	Town	Recommended	Why / notes
Sat 6 Mar	Christchurch Airport	**Novotel Christchurch Airport** (Accor), 30 Durey Road	At the airport, and the start of SH73 west. Alternatives: Peppers Christchurch Clearwater Resort (Accor, near the airport) or ibis Christchurch (Accor, city centre, adds city traffic).
Sun 7, Mon 8	Franz Josef (2 nights)	Non-Accor (Accor has no hotel on the West Coast). Look at Scenic Hotel Franz Josef Glacier or Rainforest Retreat, or any motel on the main road.	Two nights give a weather buffer for the helicopter flight. Stay in the village so dinner is walkable.
Tue 9	Wānaka	Non-Accor (no Accor in Wānaka). Any motel or hotel near the lakefront. Oakridge Resort was once a Grand Mercure but is no longer Accor.	Lakefront location makes the evening walkable.
Wed 10	Lake Tekapo	**Peppers Bluewater Resort Lake Tekapo** or **Mantra Lake Tekapo** (both Accor, Mantra Group)	Both are in the township, walkable to the lakefront, the church and the Dark Sky Project. Book quickly: Tekapo is small and fills up.
Thu 11	Oamaru	Non-Accor. Must be **within walking distance of the Blue Penguin Colony** on Waterfront Road, for example the historic Brydone Hotel on Thames Street or harbour-area motels.	Required by your no-driving-after-dark rule: the penguins arrive after sunset.
Fri 12	Dunedin	Non-Accor (no Accor in Dunedin). A central hotel near the Octagon, for example Scenic Hotel Southern Cross.	Central location gives walkable dinner and easy SH1 access in the morning.
Sat 13	Queenstown	**Novotel Queenstown Lakeside** (Accor), Earl Street and Marine Parade	Walk to the gondola and restaurants; airport 15 to 20 minutes. Saturday rates in March may be over NZ$300. If so, try Mantra The Point, Peppers Beacon or Mövenpick Queenstown (all Accor). Sofitel and Hotel St Moritz are likely over budget.

Accor nights: 3 of 8. Accor's South Island hotels are only in Christchurch, Lake Tekapo, Queenstown and Invercargill. You could reach 5 Accor nights by cutting Oamaru and Dunedin and adding a second night each in Tekapo and Queenstown. That would cost the royal albatross, both penguin species and Katiki Point's seals, and mean driving some roads twice. Given your wildlife interest and wanting to see as much as possible, I recommend the route above.

Bookings to make, and when

Today is 9 November 2026 and nothing but the flights is booked. March is the busy end of summer, and the penguin, albatross and Tekapo bookings sell out.

#	What	For	Book by	Notes
1	One-way rental car, CHC Airport to ZQN Airport	6 to 14 Mar	**Now** (by 30 Nov 2026)	Name one driver. Ask for unlimited km, the one-way fee, a zero or low-excess cover option, the gravel-road rule, and return hours on a Sunday morning.
2	All 8 nights of accommodation	6 to 13 Mar	**Now** (by 30 Nov 2026)	Free-cancellation, two-bed rooms. Oamaru must be walkable to the colony.
3	Oamaru Blue Penguin Colony, evening viewing	Thu 11 Mar, ~20:00	By 31 Dec 2026	penguins.co.nz. Choose General or Premium.
4	Royal Albatross Centre, Unique Taiaroa tour	Fri 12 Mar, 14:00	By 31 Dec 2026	albatross.org.nz. Land-based tour; avoid the cruise combos.
5	The OPERA yellow-eyed penguin tour	Fri 12 Mar, ~16:00	By 31 Dec 2026	Afternoon slot ending by 18:00, not the twilight tour.

#	What	For	Book by	Notes
6	Franz Josef helicopter snow-landing flight (optional)	Mon 8 Mar, ~10:30	By 31 Jan 2027	Weather-dependent. Choose an operator that rebooks or refunds on cancellation.
7	Mount Cook ski-plane glacier landing (optional or backup)	Wed 10 Mar, ~14:00	Early Feb 2027, or the night before as a backup	Only if you want both flights, or if Franz Josef cannot fly.
8	Dark Sky Project stargazing (optional)	Wed 10 Mar, night	By 31 Jan 2027	Leaves from Tekapo village by tour bus; no driving.
9	Skyline Queenstown gondola	Sat 13 Mar, ~18:15	A few days before	Can also buy on the day.
10	Willowbank; West Coast Wildlife Centre	6 and 8 Mar	No booking needed	Book the Wildlife Centre Backstage Pass ahead if you want it.

Rough budget for two (NZ$, estimates to check)

Item	Estimate	Basis
Accommodation, 8 nights	~$2,000 to $2,400	Your cap of NZ$300 per night
Rental car, one-way	Get quotes	Daily rate plus the one-way fee varies widely by company
Fuel	~$450 to $550	About 2,000 km at about 8 L/100 km, about 160 L at about NZ$2.80 to $3.30 a litre
Wildlife entries and tours	~$450 to $550	Albatross ~$82 pp, OPERA ~$68 pp, Oamaru penguins ~$40 to $60 pp, Willowbank and the Wildlife Centre ~$40 to $50 pp each
Mount John toll, Skyline gondola	~$150	$8 per car; gondola about $60 to $70 pp
Helicopter flight (optional)	~$600 to $1,200	About $300 to $600 pp
Ski-plane flight (optional)	~$960 to $1,400	About $480 to $700 pp

Prices come from operator pages and resellers seen in November 2026 and may change by March 2027.

Essential info

Booked activities

None yet. Only the flights are booked: arrival CHC Sat 6 Mar 14:30, departure ZQN Sun 14 Mar 11:00. Use the booking table above; add confirmation numbers here as you book.

Driving in the South Island

- Keep left. The open-road limit is 100 km/h and many winding sections are signed lower. Average speeds are slower than the map suggests: allow about 70 to 80 km/h.
- **One-lane bridges** are common on the West Coast and Haast Pass. The smaller red arrow gives way.
- **Fuel stops** to plan: Hokitika (Day 2), Franz Josef or Fox (Day 3 evening), Haast (Day 4), Wānaka or Twizel (Day 5), Omarama (Day 6), Dunedin (Day 7 evening), Frankton (Day 8 or 9). Never let the tank fall below half on Days 2, 4 and 5.
- **Road closures:** SH73 and SH6 Haast Pass can close for slips, floods or rockfall at short notice. Check journeys.nzta.govt.nz each evening. If the Haast Pass is closed on Day 4, stay another night in Franz Josef. Once it reopens: Day 5 Franz Josef to Wānaka, Day 6 Wānaka to Mount Cook to Tekapo, Day 7 Tekapo to Dunedin (about 330 km) in time for the Otago Peninsula tours (move them if needed), Day 8 as planned. You lose Oamaru, so cancel that booking.
- **Kea** at Arthur's Pass and Mount Cook damage cars (rubber seals, wipers). Do not feed them, and do not leave the car unattended with the windows down.
- **Fatigue:** with one driver, take a 15 minute break every 1.5 to 2 hours. Days 2 and 8 are the long ones; each has a "drop first" item.
- **Wildlife rules:** stay at least 20 m from seals and penguins, use hides and lookouts only, and never use flash near penguins.

Weather and gear

- Early March is late summer. Expect about 8 to 22 °C, colder at Mount Cook and Arthur's Pass, and heavy rain is common on the West Coast. The sun is strong, so pack sunscreen and hats.
- Pack a rain jacket, a warm fleece, comfortable walking shoes with good grip (steps at the Devils Punchbowl and Tasman Glacier View), and insect repellent for West Coast sandflies.
- If you are prone to motion sickness, take it on the flights and the winding roads (Highcliff Road, Haast Pass, Glenorchy Road).

Weather backup plans

Day	If the weather is bad
2	Arthur's Pass in heavy rain: skip the Devils Punchbowl walk (creek crossing); the Otira lookout and kea are still worth a stop.
3	No helicopter: rebook for later in the day or Day 4 at 08:00, or switch to the Mount Cook ski plane on Day 5. The valley walk and Lake Matheson still work in light rain. The Wildlife Centre and Glacier Hot Pools are indoors or fine in rain.
5	Mount Cook in cloud: visit the Sir Edmund Hillary Alpine Centre at The Hermitage hotel, and keep the Tasman Glacier View for any clearer spell.
5/6	Cloudy night: skip stargazing. Mount John's road closes in bad weather; do the Tekapo lakefront instead.
7	Rain in Dunedin: the albatross and OPERA tours run in most weather (wear a jacket). Otago Museum or Toitū Otago Settlers Museum are indoor fallbacks.
8	Rain in Queenstown: skip Glenorchy. The Kiwi Birdlife Park (Brecon Street) or Arrowtown's shops are alternatives.

Must download (offline)

- Google Maps offline areas for Canterbury, the West Coast, Otago and Queenstown Lakes. There is no coverage over most of the Haast Pass and parts of Arthur's Pass.
- NZTA Journey Planner (journeys.nzta.govt.nz) for road closures; MetService app for forecasts.
- DOC track pages (doc.govt.nz) for Devils Punchbowl, Franz Josef Glacier Walk, Blue Pools, Kea Point and Tasman Glacier View: alerts show closures.
- Gaspy (fuel prices), your rental company's app, and your airline app.
- PDF or screenshots of all bookings, in case there is no signal.

Local spots (check hours before going; not verified for March 2027)

Where	Coffee / food
Sheffield (Day 2)	Sheffield Pie Shop, on SH73
Franz Josef (Days 2 and 3)	Snakebite Brewery; Alice May (both on the main road)
Wānaka (Day 4)	Big Fig; Kai Whakapai (Ardmore Street, lakefront)
Mount Cook (Day 5)	Old Mountaineers' Café (village)
Tekapo (Days 5 and 6)	Kohan Japanese (SH8); Astro Café (Mount John summit)
Twizel (Day 6)	High Country Salmon farm shop (SH8, canal just north of Twizel)
Dunedin (Day 7)	Vogel St Kitchen (Vogel Street, warehouse precinct)
Queenstown (Day 8)	Fergburger, 42 Shotover Street; Stratosfare (Skyline, Bob's Peak)

Considered but left out, and why

Left out	Reason
Milford Sound and Doubtful Sound	The main experience is a boat cruise. A day trip by road from Queenstown is about 580 km return, over your 500 km limit.
Kaikōura whale watching, Tasman Lake glacier boat, Shotover Jet, Otago Peninsula wildlife cruises	Boats.
Moeraki Boulders, Tunnel Beach, Sandfly Bay, Hokitika Beach	Beaches.
Hooker Valley Track (full), Roys Peak, Ben Lomond, Mount John summit walk from town	Each is longer than about 2 hours. Shorter alternatives are in the plan.
Glacier heli-hike	2 to 3 hours walking on ice. The scenic flight with a snow landing is included instead.
International Antarctic Centre	Closes at 16:30 and needs about 3 hours; it does not fit an afternoon arrival.

Quick reference

Schedule overview

Day	Date	Key activity	Overnight
1	Sat 6 Mar	Land 14:30; Willowbank kiwi	Christchurch Airport (Novotel, Accor)
2	Sun 7 Mar	Castle Hill, Devils Punchbowl, kea, Hokitika Gorge	Franz Josef
3	Mon 8 Mar	Lake Matheson, helicopter snow landing, glacier walk, kiwi centre	Franz Josef
4	Tue 9 Mar	Haast Pass waterfalls, Blue Pools, The Neck, Mount Iron	Wānaka
5	Wed 10 Mar	Lindis Pass, Peter's Lookout, Kea Point, Tasman Glacier, Good Shepherd	Lake Tekapo (Peppers or Mantra, Accor)
6	Thu 11 Mar	Mount John, Waitaki lakes, Elephant Rocks, blue penguins	Oamaru
7	Fri 12 Mar	Katiki Point seals, royal albatross, yellow-eyed penguins	Dunedin
8	Sat 13 Mar	Kawarau Gorge, Arrowtown, Glenorchy road, Skyline	Queenstown (Novotel, Accor)
9	Sun 14 Mar	Return car ~08:30; fly 11:00	Home

Critical prep

- **This month:** book the one-way rental car and all 8 hotels (two-bed rooms, free cancellation).
- **By end of December:** book the Oamaru penguins, the Royal Albatross Centre and The OPERA.
- **By end of January:** decide on and book the helicopter flight (and the optional stargazing).
- **Before flying:** clean walking shoes, get any NZeTA or visa needed (if not an Australian citizen), check that your travel insurance covers rental-car excess, and download offline maps.
- **Each evening:** check NZTA road status and the forecast, fuel up as listed, and confirm next-day times.